Keep the evidence on the question

Explain whether a fact bears on the specific claim being judged.

Suggested teaching time: 20 min | Preparation: about 5 min

Introductory | Secondary and adult learners | Individual writing, pairs, and class discussion

Prerequisites: None

Students will be able to

- Identify the action and outcome in a claim.
- Explain how a supplied fact bears on that claim.
- Distinguish relevance from truth, vividness, and proof of cause.

Prepare and gather

- One student handout per learner, or display the activities and use paper.
- Pens or pencils; no student devices required.
- Keep the instructor guide and model answers separate from student materials.
- Read the three scenarios and their model answers.
- Print the student handout or display one activity at a time.
- Explain that all scenarios are invented and students should use only the supplied facts.

Teaching sequence

4 min	**Name the question.** Learners complete the cafeteria warm-up. Ask which outcome the claim concerns before discussing either fact.
7 min	**Check the hotel evidence.** Pairs identify the action and outcome, then explain why each hotel fact does or does not bear on the claim.
4 min	**Separate relevance from proof.** Reveal the model answer and use the discussion prompts. A relevant comparison can still leave causal questions unresolved.
5 min	**Apply the test independently.** Learners complete the library exit ticket. Assess their connection between the evidence and the exact outcome.

Timings are suggested starting points, not measured classroom completion times.

Warm-up / Shorter lunch queues

Student task and instructor answer

Explain these words as needed

Relevance: A connection between information and the particular question being judged.

Outcome: The result a claim says an action affects.

Comparison: Examining cases side by side using the same relevant measure.

Scenario

Invented scenario: A cafeteria claims opening a second till shortens lunch queues. Fact A: average waits were four minutes with two tills open and seven with one, on comparable lunch days. Fact B: students liked the new wall mural.

Student output: Name the claimed outcome and explain the relevance of each fact.

1. State what the extra till is claimed to change.

2. Choose the fact that directly compares that outcome.

3. Explain why the other fact does not answer this question.

Student success check: Are you judging queue waiting time rather than how pleasant the room looks?

Model answer

The claimed outcome is shorter waits. Fact A directly compares waits with one and two tills. Liking a mural does not show whether the extra till shortens waits.

Why this meets the task: It links relevance to the exact action and outcome without declaring the comparison conclusive proof of cause.

Main activity / Which hotel fact matters?

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: A hotel manager claims text reminders reduce hallway noise complaints. Fact A: comparable floors receiving reminders had four complaints per 100 occupied room-nights, versus seven on floors without reminders in the same month. Fact B: most guests liked the new lobby painting. A room-night means one occupied room for one night.

Student output: Write the claim's action and outcome, then explain the relevance of Fact A and Fact B.

1. Name the action and the outcome in the claim.

2. Choose which fact bears directly on the claim and explain the connection.

3. Explain why the other fact does not answer this question, even if it is true.

Student success check: Have you linked the evidence to reminders and noise complaints, rather than to general guest satisfaction?

Model answer

The action is sending text reminders; the outcome is hallway noise complaints. Fact A compares that outcome with and without reminders using the same unit. Fact B concerns a painting and does not show whether reminders affect noise complaints.

Why this meets the task: The answer explains relevance through the specific action and outcome. Relevance alone does not prove the comparison establishes cause.

Exit ticket / Returning library books on time

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: A librarian claims reminder emails reduce late book returns. Fact A: in the same month, comparable borrowers sent reminders returned 8 of every 100 books late; borrowers without reminders returned 13 of every 100 late. Fact B: the library website won a design award.

Student output: Write the action and outcome, choose the relevant fact, and explain why the other fact does not answer the claim.

1. Name the action being assessed and the result it is meant to affect.

2. Explain how one fact compares that result with and without the action.

3. Explain why the other fact, even if true, does not test this claim.

Student success check: Have you kept late returns separate from the website's appearance or reputation?

Model answer

Action: sending reminder emails. Outcome: late book returns. Fact A compares late-return rates with and without reminders in the same month. The design award does not show whether reminder emails change late returns.

Why this meets the task: The explanation identifies the connection that makes Fact A relevant. It does not assume the borrower comparison eliminates every alternative explanation.

Check understanding

Mark each criterion met or needs another attempt. Accept equivalent wording; assess the reasoning, not a memorized phrase.

- The action and outcome are accurately identified.

- The relevant fact is connected to that specific outcome and comparison.

- The other fact is rejected for lack of relevance, not simply called false or unimportant.

Discussion and adaptations

Use the supplied guidance to keep the lesson focused on its reasoning skill.

Discussion prompts

Could the painting or website award be relevant to a different question?

Listen for: Yes. They could bear on questions about guest preferences or website design. Relevance depends on the claim, not on a fact being useful in every context.

Does relevant evidence automatically prove a claim?

Listen for: No. Relevance is a first test. We must also ask whether the information is accurate and the comparison fairly isolates the action's effect.

Common confusions

A positive fact supports any positive claim. Identify the exact connection. Satisfaction with a painting does not measure the effect of noise reminders.

An irrelevant fact must be false. A fact can be true and still fail to address this question.

Numbers are always more relevant than words. Numbers must measure something that bears on the claim. A numerical count of paintings would not test reminder effectiveness.

Adapt the lesson

More support: Have learners underline the action and circle the outcome. Use: "This fact matters because it tells us about ___." Accept oral explanations before writing.

More challenge: Ask for a question to which the hotel painting fact would be relevant. Expected example: "Did guests like the new lobby painting?" Explain that it still would not establish why noise complaints changed.

Next practice

https://xixteen.com/learners/?practice=relevance#workbench